

WORKPLACE GENRES, CLEAR STYLE, AND AUDIENCE-CENTERED DOCUMENT DESIGN

WEEK 2

Concise Style • Plain Language • Technical Definitions & Descriptions • Document Hierarchy • Editing for Clarity

CORE PROPOSITION

Technical communication succeeds when a real reader can find the right information, understand it the first time, and act on it with minimal friction.

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COM 310-901 • Technical Communication

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Student Learning Handbook • Week 2 • September 27-October 3, 2026

MAJOR WORK THIS WEEK

Short-Document Portfolio begins • Audience/User Analysis

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How to Use This Handbook

Week 2 moves from the idea of technical communication as professional problem-solving to the actual documents that carry work forward. The central question is not simply, “Is this well written?” It is, “Can the intended reader use this document to do what the situation requires?”

This handbook is designed for reading, annotation, and application. Each section gives you a concept, a realistic workplace example, and a practical test you can apply to your own short documents.

A USEFUL STARTING PRINCIPLE

Do not begin with sentences. Begin with the situation: Who needs what, why do they need it, and what must happen after they read?

What You Should Be Able to Do by the End of Week 2

By the end of the week, you should be able to identify the rhetorical job of common workplace genres; distinguish audience from user; build a concise audience/user profile; revise inflated prose into plain, precise language; write useful technical definitions and descriptions; design headings, lists, and visual hierarchy for scanning; and edit a short workplace document for clarity, action, and usability.

Part I. Workplace Genres: Documents That Make Work Happen

A workplace genre is a recurring document form shaped by a recurring situation. Memos, emails, status updates, incident reports, instructions, proposals, briefs, FAQs, and executive summaries exist because organizations repeatedly need people to decide, approve, record, explain, coordinate, or act.

GENRE IS A SOCIAL CONTRACT

A genre creates expectations. A status update should reveal progress and blockers quickly. An instruction should enable correct action. A recommendation should make the decision problem, evidence, and proposed action visible.

The Genre Triangle

SITUATION What happened?	→	READER Who must use this?	→	ACTION What must happen next?
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Genre	Primary job	Reader's likely question	Failure mode
Email	Coordinate or request	What do you need from me?	Purpose buried in background
Memo	Record analysis or decision	What is the issue and what follows?	Looks formal but gives no decision path
Status update	Make progress visible	What changed? What is blocked?	Chronology instead of signal
Instructions	Enable safe, correct action	What do I do first/next?	Steps omit conditions or outcomes
Brief	Compress a complex issue	What matters most right now?	Too much context, weak hierarchy
FAQ	Resolve predictable questions	Can I find my exact question fast?	Questions reflect writer, not user

Genre Selection Test

1. Name the decision or task. 2. Name the primary reader. 3. Identify the reading condition: desk, phone, meeting, field, emergency, routine. 4. Choose the smallest genre that can carry the needed information. 5. Confirm what record, action, or accountability the document must create.

Micro-case: The Server Outage

A system outage does not automatically call for “a report.” The help-desk user may need a 90-word service alert; the engineering team may need a technical incident record; leadership may need a one-page impact brief. The event is the same. The genre changes because the readers and actions change.

Part II. Audience and User Analysis

Technical communication is reader-centered, but “audience” is not a demographic label. A useful audience analysis predicts what readers know, need, value, misunderstand, and must do. Google’s technical-writing guidance asks writers to determine what an audience already knows and what it needs to learn.[1] CDC plain-language guidance similarly begins with audience and purpose.[2]

Audience vs. User

Question	Audience lens	User lens
Who?	Who receives or may encounter the document?	Who must use the information to perform a task or make a decision?
Need?	What information matters to them?	What must they accomplish successfully?
Constraint?	Knowledge, role, authority, interest	Time, device, environment, access, risk, workflow
Success?	They understand the message	They can act accurately and efficiently

The Five-Layer Audience/User Profile

Layer	Ask	Example: internship onboarding guide
1. Role	What is this person's relationship to the task?	New intern; no organizational authority
2. Knowledge	What can you safely assume?	Knows email and Teams; does not know internal file structure
3. Goal	What must the person accomplish?	Access systems and submit first-week forms
4. Constraint	What could make use difficult?	Mobile access; unfamiliar acronyms; deadline pressure
5. Consequence	What happens if communication fails?	Missed access, delayed work, privacy/security mistakes

THE KNOWLEDGE-GAP TEST

Write two sentences before drafting: “My reader already knows ____.” “My reader needs to learn ____ in order to ____.” If you cannot complete both precisely, you are not ready to draft.

Primary, Secondary, and Gatekeeping Readers

A short document can serve more than one reader. The primary reader acts on it. Secondary readers may need context or a record. Gatekeepers may approve, route, regulate, or evaluate it. Do not give every reader equal space. Design the main path for the primary user, then provide secondary detail through headings, notes, links, or appendices when needed.

Part III. Concise Style and Plain Language

Concise writing is not “short writing” at any cost. It is writing in which each word earns its place. Plain language is communication the intended audience can understand the first time.[2] CDC recommends putting the most important message first, using familiar words, active voice, logical chunks, headings, and lists.[2] Google’s Technical Writing One likewise emphasizes active voice, specific verbs, one idea per sentence, and removal of unneeded words.[1]

Before / After: Reduce Friction, Not Meaning

Problem	Before	After
Buried action	It is requested that all team members who have not yet completed the form do so prior to Friday.	Complete the form by Friday.
Nominalization	The team conducted an evaluation of the prototype.	The team evaluated the prototype.
Empty opener	There are three factors that affect upload speed.	Three factors affect upload speed.
Weak verb	The dashboard provides an indication of account status.	The dashboard shows account status.
Reader distance	Users are required to enter their credentials.	Enter your credentials.

The CLEAR Sentence Test

Letter	Question	Revision move
C - Core	Can I identify the sentence's one main idea?	Split competing ideas.
L - Lead	Does the actor/action appear early?	Move subject + strong verb forward.
E - Exact	Are nouns and verbs specific?	Replace vague terms and weak verbs.
A - Audience	Will the reader know the terms?	Define, replace, or contextualize jargon.
R - Remove	What can disappear without loss?	Cut throat-clearing, repetition, filler.

ACTIVE VOICE IS A DEFAULT, NOT A RELIGION

Active voice usually clarifies who does what. Passive voice can still be useful when the actor is unknown, irrelevant, or intentionally de-emphasized. The test is clarity and responsibility, not a mechanical ban.[3]

Plain Does Not Mean Imprecise

“Use simple words” does not mean deleting necessary technical terms. It means using the simplest accurate language for the audience. Keep a specialized term when it carries essential precision; define it at first use and use it consistently afterward.

Part IV. Technical Definitions and Descriptions

Technical definitions answer “What does this term mean here?” Technical descriptions answer “What is this thing, what are its parts or features, and how does it work or matter?” The writer’s job is to calibrate detail to the user, not to display expertise.

Three Levels of Definition

Level	Use when	Example: API
Parenthetical	The term needs only a quick cue	An API (a structured way for software systems to exchange requests and data) connects the application to the service.
Sentence	The term is central to the task	An API is an interface that defines how one software component can request data or functions from another.
Extended	The reader must reason with the concept	Define the category, purpose, parts, boundaries, examples, and non-examples; then show the term in the reader's task.

Definition Formula

TERM	→	CLASS / CATEGORY	→	DISTINGUISHING FEATURE	→	WHY IT MATTERS
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Example: “A checksum is a calculated value used to detect whether data changed during storage or transmission. If the recalculated value does not match the expected value, the file may be corrupted or altered.” The first sentence defines; the second explains practical significance.

Description by User Need

Reader	Useful emphasis	Likely unnecessary detail
New employee	Purpose, visible parts, where to find it, what to do	Internal engineering history
Technician	Components, interfaces, tolerances, states, failure indicators	Basic organizational background
Manager	Function, risk, cost, dependencies, decision implications	Low-level implementation unless it changes the decision
Customer	Benefit, operation, limits, warnings, support path	Internal process vocabulary

DEFINITION WARNING

Do not define an unfamiliar term with another unfamiliar term. A definition should reduce the reader's uncertainty, not relocate it.

Micro-exercise: “Encryption”

For a cybersecurity specialist, a definition may distinguish algorithms, keys, data at rest, and data in transit. For a new employee, the immediate need may be simpler: encryption transforms readable data into a protected form so unauthorized people cannot use it without the required key or credentials. Same concept, different depth.

Part V. Document Hierarchy and Scanability

Workplace readers rarely begin by reading every word. They scan for relevance, urgency, action, evidence, and exceptions. Information hierarchy makes the document's logic visible before the reader processes every sentence. CDC recommends breaking material into logical chunks and labeling those chunks with headings.[4]

A Practical Hierarchy

1. PURPOSE Why this exists	→	2. ACTION What to do	→	3. EVIDENCE Why / how	→	4. DETAIL Conditions & exceptions
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Headings as Navigation

Weak heading	Stronger heading	Why stronger
Background	Why the migration is happening	Names the reader's question
Information	What you need before you begin	Signals task readiness
Issues	Three risks that could delay launch	Adds number + consequence
Next Steps	Submit your approval by 4 p.m. Friday	Makes action and deadline visible

Lists: Use Structure to Expose Logic

Google recommends numbered lists when sequence matters and bullets when order does not; list items should remain grammatically parallel.[5]

Use	Choose	Example
Sequence / procedure	Numbered list	1. Sign in. 2. Select Billing. 3. Download the invoice.
Options / features	Bulleted list	The package includes: cable, adapter, mounting plate.
Comparison	Table	Compare plan, cost, storage, and support in columns.
One critical warning	Callout box	Back up the device before resetting it.

THE 10-SECOND SCAN

Give a classmate your page for ten seconds. Then hide it. Can the classmate state the purpose, the required action, and where to find the key detail? If not, revise hierarchy before revising sentences.

Visual Restraint

Hierarchy does not require decoration. In a black-and-white professional document, spacing, alignment, heading levels, rules, tables, and consistent typography can create strong navigation. Every visual distinction should signal a real distinction in meaning.

Part VI. Editing for Clarity: A Repeatable Method

Editing is not a final spell-check. It is a sequence of decisions. Editing everything at once encourages surface corrections while structural problems survive. Use passes, moving from purpose to detail.

The Six-Pass Edit

Pass	Question	What to mark
1. Purpose	Can the reader tell why this document exists?	Purpose statement, decision, requested action
2. Audience	What knowledge am I assuming?	Acronyms, jargon, missing context
3. Structure	Can the reader find the path quickly?	Headings, order, lists, repetition
4. Sentence	Is each sentence direct and precise?	Weak verbs, passive ambiguity, long sentences
5. Evidence	Are facts, numbers, and claims usable and credible?	Source, date, units, comparison, qualification
6. Surface	Is the document mechanically clean?	Grammar, spelling, punctuation, formatting consistency

Editing Marks That Reveal Problems

Mark	Meaning	Example action
[A]	Actor unclear	Name who performs the action.
[J]	Jargon / undefined term	Define, replace, or remove.
[?]	Reader may ask “what does this mean?”	Add a concrete noun, example, condition, or result.
[CUT]	No new value	Delete repetition or throat-clearing.
[MOVE]	Correct content, wrong location	Move detail under the heading where the user will look.
[ACT]	Required action is buried	Rewrite as a visible imperative with owner/deadline.

Editing Example

BEFORE

Due to the fact that the current onboarding documentation contains a number of inconsistencies, it has been determined that revisions should be made by members of the operations team prior to the next group of interns beginning their employment.

AFTER

The operations team will revise the inconsistent onboarding guide before the next interns start. Update system-access steps, contact names, and submission deadlines by October 9.

What Changed?

The revision names the actor, replaces a nominalized and passive construction with direct verbs, removes filler, identifies the concrete scope of revision, and gives a deadline. The shorter version is more useful because it increases accountability and actionability.

Part VII. Short-Document Portfolio Studio

The Week 2 major work begins your short-document portfolio. The portfolio should demonstrate that you can adapt content to a real rhetorical situation rather than produce one generic “professional” style.

Portfolio Design Logic

AUDIENCE / USER ANALYSIS	→	GENRE CHOICE	→	DRAFT	→	USABILITY CHECK	→	REVISION
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Step 1: Write the Audience/User Snapshot

Prompt	Your answer should identify
Who is the primary user?	Role, responsibility, relationship to the task
What do they already know?	Prior knowledge you can safely assume
What must they do?	Observable action or decision
What could block them?	Time, terminology, device, access, risk, motivation
What does success look like?	Correct action, informed decision, reduced error, completed task

Step 2: Choose a Short Genre

Choose a document that a workplace could plausibly use: concise email, memo, process note, FAQ, status update, one-page brief, short instruction set, or comparable genre approved for the course. The genre should fit the action rather than simply fit your preference.

Step 3: Draft the Reader's Path

Before writing paragraphs, sketch the document as a path: **purpose** → **required action** → **essential context** → **evidence/details** → **next step/contact**. Not every document uses all five stages, but every stage that appears should earn its place.

Step 4: Run a Friction Audit

Friction	Diagnostic question
Finding friction	Can the user locate the needed section immediately?
Language friction	Does any sentence require rereading?
Knowledge friction	Does the document assume unexplained knowledge?
Action friction	Is ownership, sequence, deadline, or outcome unclear?
Trust friction	Are factual claims, dates, numbers, or sources vague?

PORTFOLIO RULE OF THUMB

Do not make a document longer to make it look substantial. Make it complete enough to support the user's task and no longer.

Part VIII. Worked Example and Self-Assessment

Worked Example: From Internal Note to User-Centered Email

RAW INTERNAL NOTE

Need students to know portal maintenance is Thursday 10-11 p.m. Uploads may fail. Anyone with Friday 8 a.m. deadline should upload early. IT says saved drafts should remain, but advise download backup. Contact help desk if issue.

Audience/User Analysis

Element	Decision
Primary user	Student who needs to submit work through the portal
Goal	Submit successfully and avoid losing work
Constraint	May read on a phone; may skim; deadline pressure
Critical risk	Failed upload or unsaved work
Required action	Upload early and keep a local backup

Revised Email

SUBJECT: UPLOAD BEFORE THURSDAY'S 10 P.M. PORTAL MAINTENANCE

Action: If you have work due Friday morning, upload it before 10 p.m. Thursday.

The course portal will undergo maintenance Thursday from 10-11 p.m. Uploads may fail during that hour. Save a copy of your work on your device before the maintenance window. Existing saved drafts are expected to remain available, but a local backup protects you if access is interrupted.

If you cannot access the portal after maintenance, contact the Help Desk and keep a screenshot of any error message.

Why This Version Works

The subject line names the action and timing. The first line gives the decision before the explanation. The body separates risk, mitigation, and support. The language does not promise that nothing can go wrong; it preserves the uncertainty in “expected to remain available.”

Week 2 Self-Assessment

I can say YES if...	Check
I can name my primary user and the action my document supports.	☐
My genre matches the situation rather than merely looking professional.	☐
The most important information appears early.	☐
My terms are familiar, defined, or necessary.	☐
My headings and lists expose the document's logic.	☐
My sentences use clear actors, strong verbs, and specific nouns.	☐
I tested the document for finding, language, knowledge, action, and trust friction.	☐
I edited in passes rather than relying on spell-check alone.	☐

Week 2 Closing Synthesis

Workplace genres, audience analysis, concise style, plain language, definitions, hierarchy, and editing are not separate tricks. They are linked decisions about usability. Genre gives the document a recognizable job. Audience analysis calibrates knowledge and action. Plain language reduces processing friction. Definitions manage technical precision. Hierarchy helps readers find what matters. Editing tests whether the entire system works.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A professional document is not successful because it sounds professional. It is successful when the intended user can find, understand, trust, and use the information.

A One-Minute Pre-Submission Test

Ask	If the answer is NO...
Can a reader state the document's purpose after the first screen/page?	Move the purpose or action earlier.
Can the reader find the required action in seconds?	Use a stronger heading, lead sentence, or list.
Can the reader understand necessary technical terms?	Define or replace them.
Can the reader tell who does what and when?	Restore actors, verbs, sequence, and deadlines.
Can the reader distinguish fact, expectation, and recommendation?	Add source, qualification, or attribution.
Can the document lose 10% of its words without losing meaning?	Cut repetition and filler.

Evidence Base and Further Reading

[1] **Google for Developers.** *Technical Writing One* and course summary. Emphasizes consistent terminology, active voice, specific nouns and verbs, one idea per sentence, audience analysis, lists, document scope, and self-editing. developers.google.com/tech-writing/one

[2] **Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.** *Plain Language Materials & Resources*. Defines plain language around first-use understanding and recommends audience-first organization, important information first, active voice, familiar words, logical chunks, headings, lists, and deletion of unnecessary content. cdc.gov/health-literacy/php/develop-materials/plain-language.html

[3] **Microsoft Writing Style Guide.** *Verbs: Active and Passive Voice*. Recommends active voice in most technical content while identifying limited cases where passive voice can be useful. learn.microsoft.com/en-us/style-guide/grammar/verbs

[4] **CDC Clear Communication Index.** *Is the material organized in chunks with headings?* Explains how headings and chunking help audiences group and retrieve information. cdc.gov/ccindex/tool/page-9.html

[5] **Google for Developers.** *Lists and Tables*. Recommends numbered lists for ordered steps, bulleted lists for unordered items, parallel list structure, and contextual introductions. developers.google.com/tech-writing/one/lists-and-tables

[6] **Microsoft Writing Style Guide.** *Top 10 tips for Microsoft style and voice* and *Writing tips*. Emphasizes getting to the point, brevity, simple sentences, scanability, and globally understandable language. learn.microsoft.com/style-guide/

Week 2 scope from the COM 310 schedule: Workplace genres; concise style; plain language; technical definitions/descriptions; document hierarchy; editing for clarity. Major work: short-document portfolio begins; audience/user analysis.